

COLORED BRANCHES
OF THE
LOUISVILLE FREE PUBLIC LIBRARY

An illustrated description of the buildings together with some interesting figures concerning their cost, equipment and use. Issued to mark the Tenth Anniversary of the opening of the first free public library in America exclusively for colored readers.

LOUISVILLE, KY.
1915

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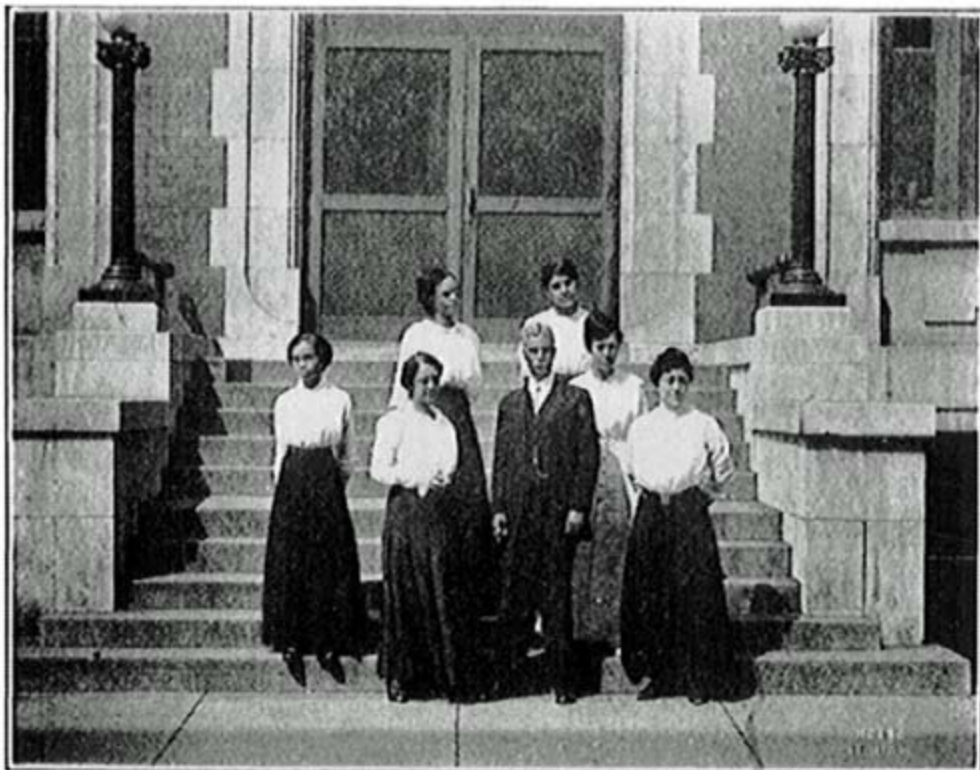
When you see a book think of the
Public Library

SUMMARY OF WORK
in the
COLORED BRANCHES
of the
LOUISVILLE FREE PUBLIC LIBRARY
For Fiscal Year Ending August 31, 1916

	Western Colored Branch	Eastern Colored Branch	TOTAL
Circulation—adult	17 821	9 289	27 110
juvenile	18 597	18 282	36 879
	36 418	27 571	63 989
Class room collections			37 303
Stations			3 841
Total circulation through all agencies			105 133
 Borrowers registered	632	270	902
Cards in force	4 025	1 298	5 323
Borrowers registered since opening	8 254	1 298	9 552
Reference topics looked up	3 493	1 484	4 977
Persons assisted in reference work since opening	29 501	3 476	32 977
Pictures loaned	1 942	805	2 747
Books added	1 484	875	2 359
Total books in library	11 269	3 850	15 119
Current periodicals and newspapers received			142
Meetings held in libraries during the year			498

Following clubs meet regularly in the buildings:

Bannecker Reading Circle	Douglass Debating Club
Fisk Club	Athletic Association
Dorcas Literary Club	Jefferson County Teachers Association
Artisans Club	Ministerial Alliance
Girls Dramatic Club	Parent-Teachers Association
Normal School Gymnastic Class	Girls Club
Physical Culture Club	Mothers Congress
Wilberforce Club	Story hour
Y. W. C. A.	



Staff—Colored Branches

COLORED BRANCHES

LOUISVILLE FREE PUBLIC LIBRARY

In organizing the public library for Louisville it was planned to have separate buildings for colored readers. The system consists of the Main library, eight branches, 230 class room collections in 35 school buildings and 62 stations, a total of 301 centers for the circulation of books for home use. This includes two branches, 52 class room collections in 13 school buildings and 6 stations, a total of 60 centers for colored readers. The total circulation of books for the year was 1,045,077. Of this number 104,771 volumes were used by colored readers.

HISTORY. After the opening of the Main library, the colored branch came next. It was opened on September 23, 1905 in temporary quarters in a residence on Chestnut Street between Tenth and Eleventh. This was the first free public library in America exclusively for colored readers and it marked an epoch in the development of the race. At the same time the Library Board purchased a corner lot, 69 by 120 feet, at Tenth and Chestnut Streets. On this site was erected a Carnegie building which was occupied: October 29, 1908.

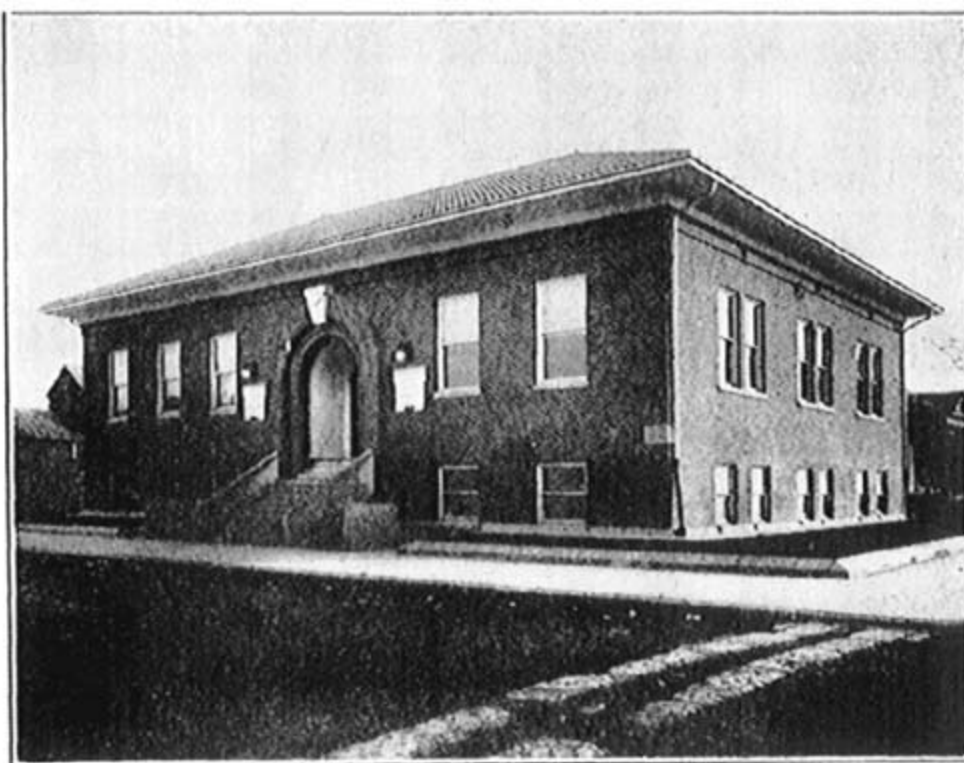


Western Colored Branch

The Western Colored Branch building is 77 feet long and 45 feet wide and is built of brick and stone with tile roof. The building has a main floor and basement. On the main floor near the entrance is the delivery desk and back of it are large tables for reading and reference. To the left on entering is a newspaper alcove, the librarian's office and the special room for children. To the right on entering is the magazine alcove, a study room and the special room for adults. The basement floor contains a large lecture room, two class rooms and supply and boiler rooms. The building is heated throughout by hot water. The furniture and shelving are beautiful in design and finish, and provision is made for free access to all the books. The arrangement is one of convenience and comfort for those who wish to read or study or to get a book for home use.

COST OF BUILDING AND EQUIPMENT

Site	\$3,105.00	
Improving grounds	1,123.68	\$4,228.68
Building construction	30,935.33	
Furniture	1,746.63	32,681.96
Books, pamphlets and periodicals		10,500.00
Total		\$47,410.64



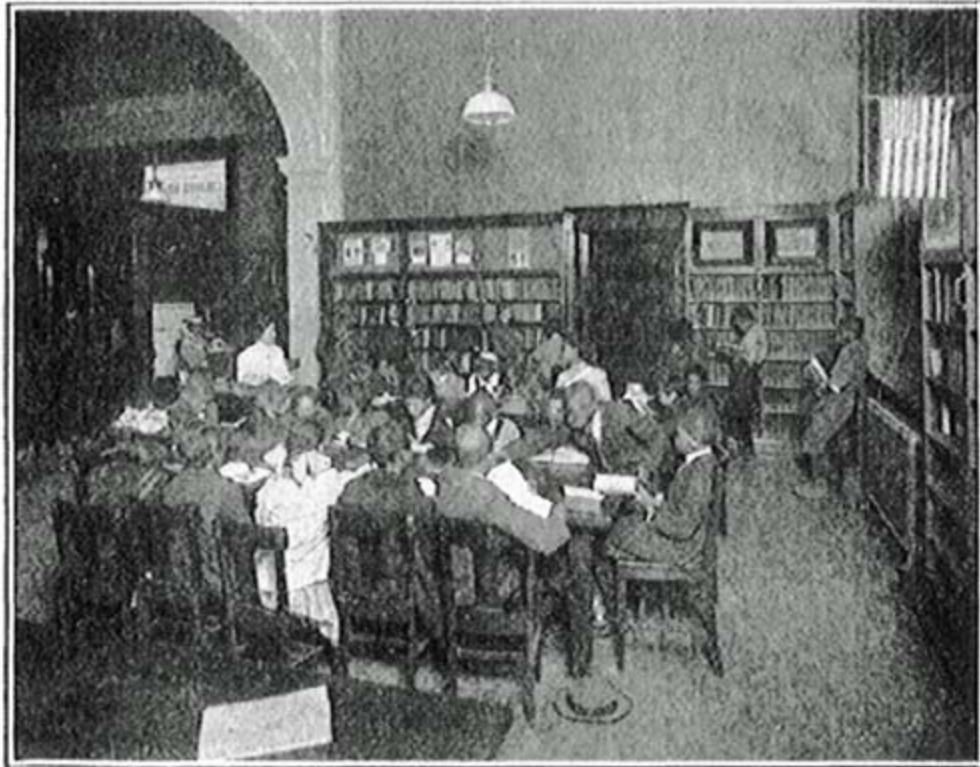
Eastern Colored Branch

The work at the first colored branch library proved so successful that a second Carnegie building was erected in the eastern part of the city. This is known as the Eastern Colored Branch, and was opened with appropriate exercises January 28, 1914.

The building is well adapted for library and social center uses. It occupies a site 75 by 150 feet at Lampton and Hancock Streets. The site cost \$5000 of which amount \$1000 was raised by colored citizens. The building is 60 by 80 feet, built of brick, concrete and stone with tile roof, and has a main floor and basement. The first floor contains the library room accommodating 10,000 volumes, the librarian's office, and an auditorium to seat 350 people. The basement has three class rooms for club use, a playroom, 37 by 40 feet, cloak room, boiler room, etc. An experimental garden is under cultivation in the "L" of the building and arrangements are under way to equip a playground 60 by 75 feet in the rear.

COST OF BUILDING AND EQUIPMENT

Site	\$5,000.00	
Improving grounds	1,000.00	\$6,000.00
Building construction	19,250.81	
Furniture	1,273.50	20,524.31
Books, pamphlets and periodicals		4,500.00
Total		\$31,024.31



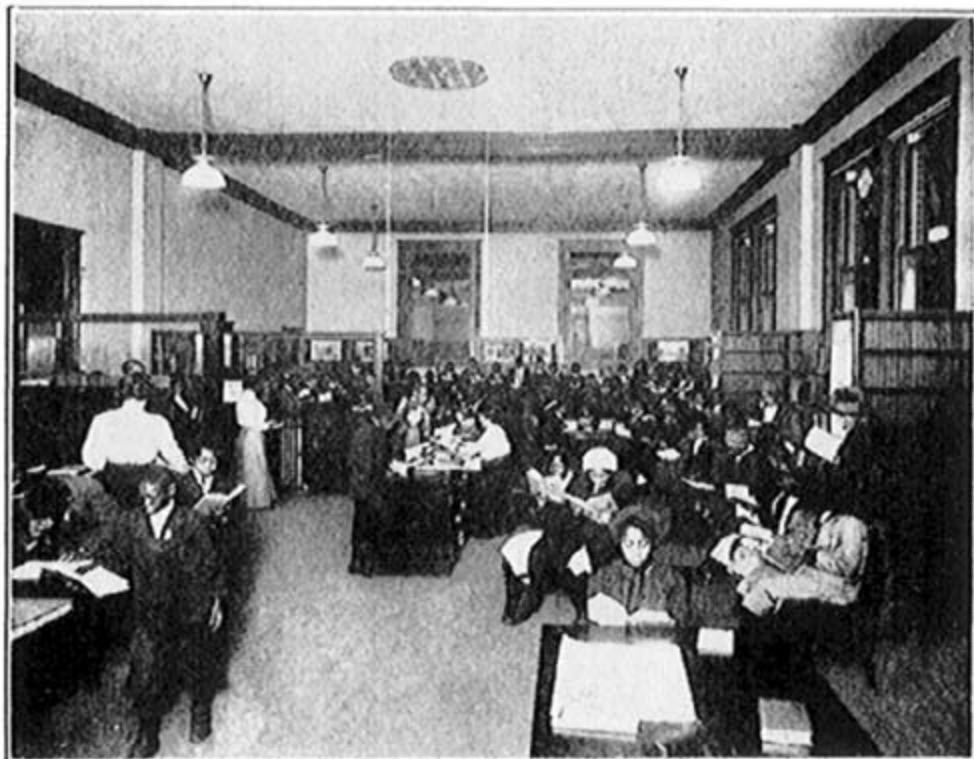
Interior Western Colored Branch

BOOKS IN THE LIBRARIES. The libraries contain 13,655 volumes; Western 10,554, Eastern 3,101, and receive 137 current periodicals and newspapers, all of which are for free use. New books are being added constantly and readers are urged to make suggestions for additions which they feel are needed and should be added to the library.

REGISTRATION. Since the opening 8,958 persons have registered as borrowers and there are now 4,866 cards in force. This number however does not represent all who use the libraries. There are numerous readers daily using books at the tables and there are school room collections which are used by the school children.

CIRCULATION. Since the opening of the libraries 595,048 volumes have been drawn for home use. The following table of circulation by years is interesting:

YEAR	VOLUMES
1905-06	17,838
1906-07	30,419
1907-08	35,910
1908-09	50,386
1909-10	58,870
1910-11	65,175
1911-12	73,462
1912-13	72,222
1913-14	85,995
1914-15	104,771
Total	595,048

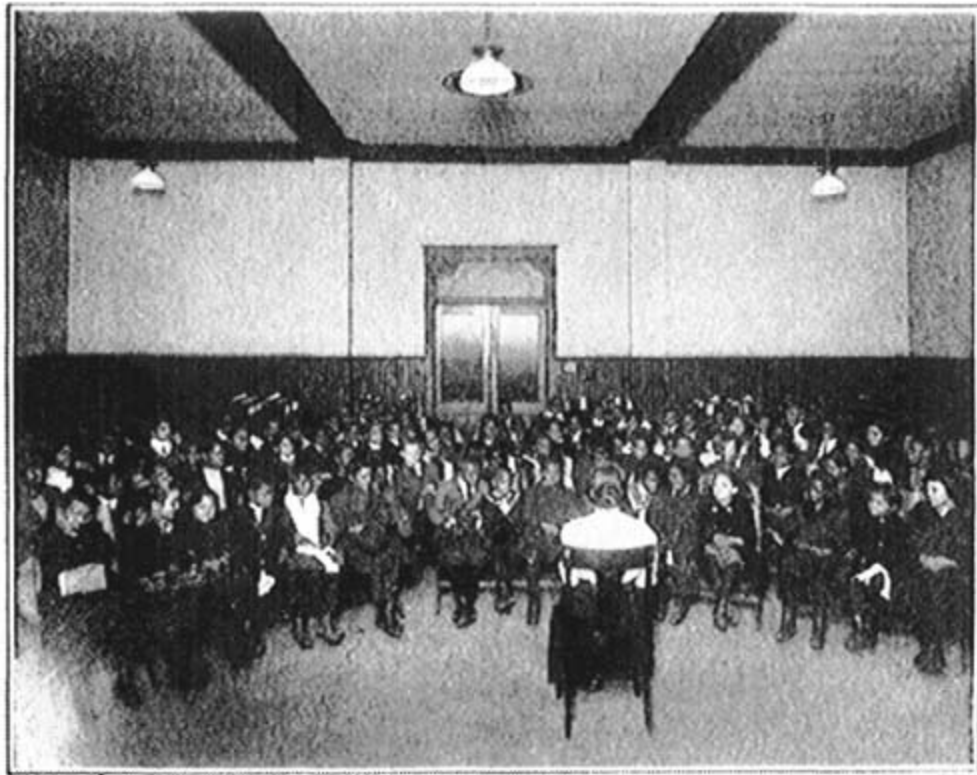


Interior Eastern Colored Branch

REFERENCE WORK. A large amount of reference work is done with the pupils and teachers of high schools and graded schools. Since the opening of the libraries 27,968 persons have been assisted in reference work by the librarians. It is impossible to keep an accurate account of the questions asked and information given.

APPRENTICE CLASS. The library conducts annually an apprentice class for those who desire to enter library service. An examination is held in June to enter a class which begins work in September. In preparing for service apprentices are given three months' work under the direction of the branch librarian, heads of departments and chief librarian. The course has been taken by twelve persons, four of whom came from other cities, Houston, Evansville, Memphis and Cincinnati, preparing for service in colored branches in these cities. Arrangements are being made to admit three young women from other cities to take the apprentice work with this year's class.

EDUCATIONAL CENTER. Close co-operation with teachers is sought in work with the schools. The libraries not only help pupils during the school life but enable them to continue studies after leaving school.



Story Hour

SOCIAL CENTER. Aside from circulating books and doing reference work, the libraries encourage and assist in all efforts to the advancement of our citizens to a social betterment. The people are made to feel that the libraries belong to them and that they may be used for anything that makes for the public welfare. During a single month forty meetings have been held in the buildings. The following clubs and reading circles meet regularly:

Artisan's Club
Banneker Reading Circle
Bena Mowya Club
Big Sisters' Committee
Douglass Debating Club
Douglass Glee Club
Fisk Club
Girls' Club
Girls' Gymnastic Club
I. K. B. Club
Jefferson County Teachers' Institute
Mu-So-Lit Reading Club
Normal Alumni
Normal School Gymnastic Class
Parent Teachers' Association
Story Hour
Sunday School Training Class
Wilberforce Club
Y. W. C. A.



Douglass Debating Club

MEETINGS IN THE LIBRARIES. The Story Hour is the children's delight and is held weekly under the direction of a trained storyteller. In addition to the pleasure that the stories give, new experiences are brought to the children, their imagination is enlarged and an interest is created in books and reading. A story telling contest is held annually and prizes are given to the children who can best reproduce a story told during the year.

The Douglass Debating Club is composed of high school boys and meets weekly under the direction of the branch librarian. The purpose of the club is to acquaint its members with parliamentary usages, to keep before them the great current questions and to train them to speak in public. Public debates are given occasionally and a prize contest is held annually. Following are some of the subjects debated:

“That the right of suffrage should be extended to women.”

“That the influence of women has contributed more to civilization than that of men.”

“That the North American Indian has had greater opportunity for development than the Afro-American.”

“That Lincoln was a greater American than Washington.”

“That the United States was justified in taking up arms against Mexico.”

“That Germany was justified in taking up arms against the Allies.”

“That the United States should interfere to stop the internal strife in Mexico.”

POPULARITY OF THE LIBRARY

The following expressions are selected from letters written by patrons of the Colored Branches:

“Next to the Public School, I regard the Public Library as the most important educational institution in the city for our people.”

W. B. MATTHEWS, *Principal*
Central Colored High School

“The influence of the Public Library has been constantly and definitely noted in the elevation of the tastes and the enlargement of the capacities of our people.”

A. E. MEYZEEK, *Principal*
Colored Normal School

“Words cannot measure the benefits we receive from our Library. It has given both old and young a new world to live in.”

JOSEPH S. COTTER, *Principal*
S. Coleridge Taylor Colored School

“For information, the dissemination of intelligence and the consequent advancement of general culture for the colored people of Louisville, the Public Library outranks any other single agency.”

G. M. McCLELLAN, *Principal*
Paul Dunbar Colored School

“The Public Library is the center for intellectual improvement and a positive force in the civic uplift for our people in Louisville.”

G. W. JACKSON, *Principal*
Lincoln Colored School

“The Colored Branches are potent factors in making intelligent, cultured and useful citizens.”

LUCIE N. DUVALLE, *Principal*
Phyllis Wheatley Colored School

“We have found the Public Library exceedingly helpful alike to teachers and to pupils.”

WILLIAM H. PERRY, *Principal*
Western Colored School

“The Public Library gives educational advantages to the colored youth of the community which means a better citizenship.”

BESSIE L. ALLEN, *Probation Officer*
Juvenile Court

“The tenth anniversary of the Colored Public Library—we are ten years old in good thoughts and good books.”

D. LEROY FERGUSON, *Rector*
Church of Our Merciful Saviour

“There are more colored people reading in Louisville now than in any time since the days of freedom. This opportunity has been given them by the Public Library.”

REV. C. H. PARRISH, *President*
Kentucky Home Finding Society

“The Colored Branch Library in Louisville has been the harbinger of countless blessings to our colored citizens.”

REV. JESSE B. COLBERT, *Presiding Elder*
A. M. E. Zion Church

“After ten years—I can say that nothing has been instituted in our city in this same length of time which has meant as much for the general culture of our people as has the Public Library.”

C. B. ALLEN, *Pastor*
Knox Presbyterian Church

“No greater blessing has come to the colored people of Louisville in the form of an institution than the Public Library.”

E. G. HARRIS, *Pastor*
Plymouth Congregational Church

“The Public Library has been of more value to the community than we can possibly express.”

DR. W. H. SHEPPARD,
Former Missionary to Africa

“The Colored Library in Louisville as a public institution is not only profitable but indispensable to our people.”

DR. P. R. PETERS, *Editor*
The Colored Herald

“The Library since its establishment has proven to be the most valuable asset of the community.”

LEE L. BROWN, *Editor*
Louisville News

“The two Colored Branch libraries have met a great need among our people in their general development.”

C. H. BULLOCK, *Secretary*
Colored Y. M. C. A.

“I have watched with interest the growth of the Public Library and its influence upon the people and I desire to state that it is in many ways exceedingly helpful and beneficial.”

WM. H. STEWARD, *President*
Louisville Negro Business Men's League

“I regard the Public Library as incomparably the most Important auxiliary in the city to the educational system for our people.”

DR. E. D. WHEDBEE, *President*
Red Cross Association

“The value of the Public Library as a factor in the race's uplift intellectually, morally and spiritually cannot be overestimated.”

J. R. HARVEY, *Pastor*
Quinn's Chapel, A. M. E. Church

“The Colored Branch Library has proven a decided advantage and an inspiration to the colored people of Louisville.”

W. J. WALLS, *Pastor*
Broadway A. M. E. Zion Church

LOUISVILLE FREE PUBLIC LIBRARY

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Tenth and Chestnut Streets	Lampton and Hancock Streets

Hours: Daily 10 a.m. to 9 p.m. Hours: 2 to 9 p.m. daily including
Sundays and holidays 2 to 9 p.m. Sundays and holidays

Libraries closed all day Fourth of July and Christmas

TRANSCRIBER'S NOTES:

Obvious typographical errors have been corrected.

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